Persian relations with the Deccan Sultanates and Ottoman naval encroachment around Gujarat. But despite this rivalry and the power disparity in the Mughals' favour, the rulers of India ultimately accepted the Ottomans and Safavids as peers. [50]

The Delhi Sultanate and Mughal Empire were, of course, not the only medieval Indian entities to have extensive interactions with the outside world before the era of European colonial dominance. In the Deccan, a booming trade across the Arabian Sea continued through the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries, with the export of rice, sugar, textiles, jewels, and luxury foods, in exchange for horses, slaves, gold, pearls, and silk from Arabia, Africa, the Caucasus, and China. The Vijayanagara Empire that dominated south India from the fourteenth to sixteenth centuries likely received tribute from overseas, including from what is today Myanmar and Sri Lanka. It was central to trading networks linking Europe and the Middle East to China and Southeast Asia. [51] The cosmopolitanism of the Vijayanagara Empire is reflected in the architecture of its ruined capital Hampi. There were curious military associations as well. In the fifteenth century, Vijayanagara ruler Deva Raya I reorganized his military with a focus on cavalry and mounted archers. These were imported from Persia and Arabia, while Turkish bowmen were hired during a period of remarkable political expansion. [52] After initial European contacts were established, Krishna Deva Raya used Portuguese mercenaries and their matchlock guns to great effect in battles against Bijapur, although he inexplicably did not invest further in gunpowder technologies. [53] In decline by the late sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, the rulers of Vijayanagara also had early interactions with Portuguese, Dutch, and English traders and explorers, permitting European trading stations along the Indian coast. [54]

Confederacies and Generals: Early Modern India, c. 1600–1862

The period after 1707 saw the gradual dissolution of the Mughal Empire. Governors in Punjab, Awadh, and Bengal became functionally independent, Gujarat experienced political strife, the Nizam in Hyderabad defeated two